

Regulators Under Threat?

The Role of Voters in Mediating Populist Politicians' Attacks Against Independent Regulatory Agencies

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Introduction

Independent regulatory agencies (IRAs) are seemingly under constant attack: whether one looks at Trump's undermining of the Fed's independence, Orbán's de facto usurpation of Hungary's central bank, or Erdoğan's control of the High Council for Broadcasting (RTÜK), Turkey's media regulator, the overarching picture is one of IRAs' independence being continuously threatened. An important common theme across these attacks concerns the actors behind them: populist politicians.

This might perhaps seem unsurprising, due to the very nature of IRAs: as non-elected bodies that formally independent from political control, staffed with technical experts and tasked with overseeing essential tenets of public policy (Maggetti 2010), IRAs can easily become the caricature of the "elites" in populists' Manichean worldview of a society divided "into two homogeneous and antagonistic groups, 'the pure people' versus 'the corrupt elite'" (Mudde 2004, 543). Indeed, regardless of whether one focuses on central banks, environmental agencies, or competition regulators, IRAs have indeed often been the target of attacks that used this framing (Jung 2025; Bersch and Lotta 2024; Bernatt 2025).

Nevertheless, one aspect that remains surprisingly unclear is the role public opinion—the principal audience that populists claim to defend when orchestrating these attacks—in enabling or constraining the effectiveness of populist underi. Despite existing literature having examined how factors ranging from institutions and fiscal rules to markets and courts might constrain or exacerbate the impact of populists' attacks on independent regulators, the role of public opinion has been notably overlooked. This paper thus asks the following question:

In what ways does public opinion—or the lack thereof—mediate the impact of populist attacks on the independence of IRAs?

Literature Review

My literature view will thus follow this structure, split into the sections below:

- Definitions: IRAs, populism, politicization
- Strategies used by populist politicians to undermine IRAs: (i) de-delegation and legal restructuring, (ii) politicized appointments and institutional capture, and (iii) resource allocation and budgetary control.
- Resistance of IRAs: How, when, and under what circumstances, do independent regulators resist these attacks?
- Potential mediators that enable or constrain the effectiveness of these attacks: institutions and fiscal rules (Enns-Jedenastik 2016; Jung 2025), TRNs, markets (Gavin and Manger 2023), courts (Goodhart and Lastra 2018), and the public

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